reaching [the emperor]', and he makes no bones about how he planned to stop the meeting: Abul Fazl would have to die.[30]

Salim sent a message to Bir Singh Bundela – son of Raja Madhukar of Orchha whom Murad had once attempted to chastise. Salim, more clever than his brother, had made friends with the discontented Bundelas. Now, Bir Singh was to 'waylay the miscreant [Abul Fazl] and dispatch him to nonexistence', writes Salim, 'in return for which he could expect great rewards from me'.

It happened exactly so. On 12 August 1602, Abul Fazl was almost exactly halfway between Orchha and Agra, riding past a village called Antri in Bundela territory, when Bir Singh and his men fell upon him. It wasn't, strictly speaking, an ambush: the writer had advance warning of the trap, but insisted on riding into it. As the Bundela king galloped towards him, the leader of Abul Fazl's escort, Gadai Khan Afghan, tried to make him escape. Again, Abul Fazl refused, dismissing every argument, preferring death to the disgrace of fleeing from an 'unwashed thief'. What would Akbar think of him if he did otherwise?

'My gracious sovereign has raised me from the rank of a student to the lofty position of an amir, a vizier, and a general. On this day, if I act contrary to [his] opinion of me, by what name shall I be called among men . . .[?]'[31]

In vain did Gadai Khan tell the historian that it was perfectly acceptable to flee a battle and fight another day; in vain did the Afghan grab the writer's reins and try to turn his horse around. The 'brave man urged on his steed', writes Inayatullah, and rode straight at 'a spear thrust in the breast'.

Inayatullah may have based his account of the murder on the memoirs of Asad Beg, a long-time employee of Abul Fazl's. Asad Beg had been left behind by the writer when Abul Fazl rode into Bundelkhand; it was he whom Akbar summoned, afterwards, for details of his friend's death. Asad Beg was not a witness to the scene, and may have more reason even than Inayatullah to embellish his master's final moments in melodrama, but his account contains a detail or two to suggest that, for all the nobility of his dash into harm's way, Abul Fazl did, in the end, make a last-ditch, instinctive bid for life.

Asad Beg, too, writes that one of Abul Fazl's men tried to lead him away;